

states KARNATAKA

The Bangalore airport hopes to overcome the legal, technical and infrastructural quagmire that it is mired in, to show the way to other Indian airports

■ By Nirmala Ravindran

Creating a virtual south Indian hub for air traffic in India, the Bangalore airport, hot on the heels of the Hyderabad International Airport, will open its swish doors to herald a sea change in the way we look at airports. The two most-awaited airports are expected to open within weeks of each other and hope to set new standards not just in air travel but also in airport infrastructure in the country. Completed in record time, Bangalore International Airport Ltd (BIAL) continues to insist on meeting its intended deadline of March 30, though the Ministry of Civil Aviation (MOCA) has confirmed that there will be a delay of four weeks, pushing the inauguration to the last week of April due to technical

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reasons. The long road to the inauguration has been wrought with obstacles like public interest litigations, clearances from Air Traffic Control and inadequate access roads to the airport. The problems started with the initial pullout by the Tata-led consortium in 1998, followed by the resignation of the then BIAL chairperson Infosys's Narayana Murthy after a fracas with former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda. With air traffic in Bangalore having grown by a whopping 38 per cent in 2007 (the highest for any Indian city), the new airport hasn't come a day too soon.

Despite the brouhaha, the nationwide indefinite strike by the employees of the Airports Authority of India (AAI) from March 12, asking for both the old airports, in Bangalore and Hyderabad, to be kept open may delay its opening. Though MOCA has promised to look into

their demands, there is little it can do as it has signed a contract with the private company explicitly stating that there shall be no airport within a radius of 150 km of the new airport for the next 25 years. Any move to the contrary by the Government will be seen as reneging on the contract.

A collaboration between private operators, which includes the Unique Zurich Airport, Larsen & Toubro and Siemens Projects, and public promoters like the Karnataka State Investment and Industrial Development Corporation and the AAI, BIAL, is all set to change the poor image of Indian airports. With a three-tiered airport terminal, common for domestic as well as international

travellers, with 54 check-in counters and an additional six common use self service devices and nine aerobridges, it promises to be on the lines of an international airport. In the international section there will be 18 counters for immigration and two aircraft bays. Hopefully, managing the initial capacity of 11 million passengers annually should now be easy with these facilities.

In addition to the basic facilities, BIAL

has also identified concessionaires which will operate from the premises to make the "airport experience complete", says BIAL CEO Albert Brunner, who took over after Murthy. The international departure area will see mono brands like designer wear from Deepika Govind, watches



"Concessionaires will make it a complete airport experience."

ALBERT BRUNNER, CEO, BANGALORE INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LTD

